

Chapter 75 - Marriage Fate

"Dual cultivation..." Chu Qingqiu's eyes flickered as she gripped the door panel. "But she's only..."

"Only what? She's been cultivating for over twenty years now. If she were in the mortal world, she'd be old enough to marry at this age." Jiang Li smiled with curved eyes. "Besides, this dual cultivation method isn't really about getting married - it's just merging and intertwining divine consciousness to achieve cultivation purposes."

"Though, the effect is... similar..." Jiang Li scratched her head.

"So after thinking for so many days, this is the only method you came up with?" Chu Qingqiu looked up.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling, you know how tricky the young sect master's condition is. Being able to think of this one method is already good." Jiang Li waved the flowers in her hand. "I dare guarantee that even if you asked every medical immortal under heaven, there would be no better solution."

"However, this places extremely high requirements on the person who would dual cultivate with her. After all, what's in her sea of consciousness is unclear. If it were someone with low cultivation, not only might they be unable to suppress that tree, they could also suffer backlash from the demonic energy in the tree."

"There really aren't many in Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate who could bear this responsibility." Jiang Li tapped the flower against her lips, thinking hard. "Her fellow disciples all have similar cultivation levels to hers."

"Those with high cultivation are all elders, which wouldn't be appropriate."

Hearing these words, Chu Qingqiu felt suffocated with frustration, her fingertips clenched until they lost all color.

But Jiang Li seemed not to notice her expression and continued listing candidates: "However, I do think there's one person who's suitable."

Chu Qingqiu used all her strength to release her grip, barely keeping herself from crushing her door panel, forcing herself to speak calmly: "Who?"

"Jiuying." Jiang Li said.

There was a crack sound, and the wooden door beside Jiang Li suddenly split, revealing the yellow interior, startling Jiang Li so much she nearly jumped out of the doorframe.

Jiang Li looked at the door, then at Chu Qingqiu, curving her lips: "Sooner or later I'll be scared to death in your Jingshan Palace, Divine Venerable."

"Why Jiuying? She's a beast!" Chu Qingqiu said.

"She's a divine beast, and she's already taken human form, so it doesn't matter. Moreover, she and the young sect master are in a contracted state, so merging divine consciousness would be easier than with others." Jiang Li said.

"Absurd." Chu Qingqiu turned her back, hiding her reddened fingertips in her sleeves. "A spirit contract lasts a lifetime - they have a master-servant relationship. How could they engage in dual cultivation? This violates propriety!"

Jiang Li covered her red lips and smiled, sighing regretfully: "The Divine Venerable makes a good point. Then I really don't know who else would be suitable."

"But anyway, the method exists. I still need to go down the mountain to tell the young sect master. Whether to dual cultivate or not, and with whom - she should know about it too." Jiang Li turned to leave but was blocked by several flying feathers.

Chu Qingqiu gritted her teeth: "I'll go with you."

Meanwhile, down at Starpoint Town.

A group of four crossed the bustling stone bridge. Ning Fuyi and the other two walked ahead in their sect robes, while Jiuying leisurely followed behind, holding two roasted chickens and proudly observing the novelties on both sides while elegantly gnawing on the chicken.

"Fuyi, why did you suddenly want these Bright Sun Grass¹?" Liu Wenzhu held two golden little grasses in her hands, asking gently.

"Bright Sun Grass grows on mountain peaks with the most brilliant sunlight - it's excellent material for making Poison-Avoiding Pills." Rong Jin said with his hands behind his back, then looked at Ning Fuyi. "You want to make Poison-Avoiding Pills?"

"Yes." Ning Fuyi said.

"Ordinary poisons can't harm us anyway. What do you need Poison-Avoiding Pills for?" Liu Wenzhu handed the little grass back to Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi carefully put away the Bright Sun Grass, smiling: "Poison-Avoiding Pills don't just ward off poison - they also have a sobering effect. If there are any confusing mists or illusion arrays, you just need to take one pill to avoid being deceived."

Given that she'd been fainting from headaches recently, she thought of refining these Poison-Avoiding Pills to prevent herself from losing consciousness at crucial moments.

Besides, Chu Qingqiu was avoiding her anyway, so with nothing else to do, she might as well make a trip down the mountain.

Ning Fuyi thought about this as she reached into her Thought Pearl to touch the blue feather. The feather was ice cold with no feeling of incoming messages.

Why was Chu Qingqiu avoiding her? Could it really be as Jiuying said - that she felt something for her...

Ning Fuyi slightly closed her phoenix eyes. She had never been as confused as these past few days, unable to see through Chu Qingqiu or understand herself. So she simply came down the mountain to do something to distract herself.

"Eh, where's Jiuying?" Liu Wenzhu noticed no one was behind them as they walked, pulling Ning Fuyi to turn and look. They saw Jiuying squeezed in the middle of a crowd on the bridge, only her red dress hem visible.

Ning Fuyi was speechless. She patted Liu Wenzhu's shoulder, turned around, and strode back, grabbing Jiuying's arm to drag her out: "Jiuying, what are you looking at now!"

Jiuying's hair had turned black for the trip down the mountain, and her clothing was the same as ordinary people's. She was reluctant to leave the crowd, pushing Ning Fuyi away: "You girl, why are you pulling me?"

"If I don't pull you, you'll stick your head into the pot." Ning Fuyi flicked her long sleeves, looking over the crowd to see inside. It was a stall with a table making dragon's beard candy, with a pot bubbling away, cooking sugar.

"Don't think that just because you formed a contract with me, you're really my master and can actually control me." Jiuying patted the sleeve Ning Fuyi had grabbed, glancing at her sideways.

Ning Fuyi looked at her with a half-smile, pulling out a money pouch from her waist and waving it in front of Jiuying.

Jiuying's eyes followed the money pouch, lowering her hands and smiling charmingly: "Occasionally managing me is fine."

Just as Jiuying was about to reach for the money pouch, Ning Fuyi quickly pulled her hand back: "From the mountain to down here, you've been eating and playing all the way. You've emptied both Senior Brother Rong Jin's and Wenzhu's money pouches."

"And you say Ping'an has nothing to do with you - your appetites are practically cut from the same mold." Ning Fuyi tied the money pouch back to her waist. "There's still the night market later, so save some."

With that, she left Jiuying behind and went down the bridge alone, leaving Jiuying standing there licking her lips at the sweet-smelling dragon's beard candy.

"Being human is such a hassle - you have to buy food instead of just taking it." She sighed deeply.

The sun soon set, and Starpoint Town lived up to its name. Throughout the town, every household lit lanterns in front of their doors like stars scattered across the earth. The streets grew more crowded with men and women out for the Qixi Festival², each carrying flower lanterns. From a distance, it looked like a sea of lights.

Though this place wasn't as luxurious as the capital of Qi Kingdom, it was no less lively. Especially when the night market arrived and numerous sky lanterns flew into the air, it became truly poetic and dreamlike.

"Wow, Fuyi, look!" Liu Wenzhu pulled Ning Fuyi to see the flower lanterns hanging from every eave. "So beautiful! Every year during Qixi we've been stuck in the mountains practicing. This is the first time we've come down to play."

"So beautiful." She spun around in delight.

"Indeed. Not just you - I've never seen this either." Rong Jin also looked up, taking out some copper coins to buy two flower lanterns, giving one each to Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu.

"Good thing we didn't give all our silver to Jiuying, or we couldn't even afford flower lanterns." Rong Jin smiled warmly.

Ning Fuyi held the rabbit-shaped flower lantern, walking along the street, when she saw a river crossing ahead with many pink flower lanterns floating in it, drifting from upstream past this point. A stone bridge spanned the river with many wind chimes hanging from its sides.

When the wind blew, the entire bridge rang with clear chiming sounds.

"Marriage Bridge." Liu Wenzhu read word by word from the stone tablet by the bridge, looking puzzled at Ning Fuyi. "What does this Marriage Bridge mean? Why are so many people standing on it, blocking the path?"

Ning Fuyi naturally didn't know either, so she stopped a man who had just come down from the bridge to ask.

The man's face was glowing as he said: "This Marriage Bridge is the oldest bridge in our Starpoint Town. Legend says it was formed from the Marriage Brush dropped by the Marriage God from heaven. They say if lovers walk across this bridge together and the wind chimes ring when they reach the center, they're fated to be together. If the wind chimes don't ring, it might be an ill-fated relationship."

"So mysterious?" Rong Jin touched his head. "What if there's no lover?"

Hearing this, the man pointed to the top of the bridge: "See? There are many people standing in the center of the bridge. Legend says if a person goes up from here and happens to meet someone face-to-face in the center of the bridge, that person is your destined one."

"Whether it's a good or bad fate depends on whether the wind chimes ring or not."

"Thank you." Ning Fuyi smiled at him.

"So magical - I'd like to try." Liu Wenzhu pulled Ning Fuyi and Rong Jin toward the bridge, but Rong Jin quickly stepped back, waving his hands.

"You two go ahead. I'm devoted to immortal cultivation with no other desires - I wouldn't dare seek any destined person." Rong Jin's face reddened. "I'm not going up."

Hearing this, Liu Wenzhu remembered something and became dejected: "If Senior Brother hadn't mentioned it, I would have forgotten. Father strictly forbids me from thinking about such romantic matters - he won't let worldly affairs affect my cultivation."

"If it's fake, that's fine, but if I really meet some destined person, that would be troublesome." She also stepped back, saying softly: "I won't go either. Fuyi, you go!"

Ning Fuyi didn't believe in this marriage bridge nonsense and was about to leave with them, but suddenly an arm reached out from the crowd, wrapping around her waist and pulling her toward the bridge.

Jiuying's zither-like voice rang in her ear: "Since we're here, why hesitate? If they won't go, let this divine beast accompany you!"

Before Ning Fuyi could react, she was already being dragged up the steps. She could only gesture to Liu Wenzhu, telling them to explore on their own first and meet up later, then turned to join the crowd on the bridge.

The bridge was packed with people shoulder to shoulder. Those at the top stayed too long, making each step extremely difficult.

"There are so many fun things in the human world." Jiuying pulled Ning Fuyi along, stopping and starting, her face full of smiles.

"You're a divine beast who's lived for tens of thousands of years, and you still believe these legends?" Ning Fuyi was pushed and swayed by the crowd, scoffing.

Jiuying's red lips curved up in a meaningful smile.

"I actually met the Marriage God once when I was young. He does indeed have a Marriage Brush for drawing destinies, with a copper bell hanging from it." Jiuying said.

Ning Fuyi's steps paused slightly.

As they spoke, the long queue had shortened, and Ning Fuyi found herself at the center of the bridge. Jiuying had somehow been pushed behind her by the crowd.

Ning Fuyi turned back to look for her but couldn't find her. She had to turn around, and just as the man in front of her stepped aside, she crashed into a pair of star-like eyes.

Her heartstrings immediately tightened, and the noisy sounds of the surrounding crowd instantly faded away.

The two faced each other, stopping in the center of the bridge, looking at each other with surprise. Countless people walked past them, stirring up gentle breezes.

"Divine, Divine Venerable." Ning Fuyi's throat felt blocked by something, her mouth opening twice before she could speak.

Facing her was indeed Chu Qingqiu, but she wasn't wearing her usual robes. Instead, she wore a white silk dress embroidered with flowers, with gauze draping from her cloud shoulders, enveloping her figure.

The lights flickered through the gauze like an immortal in a painting, a moon in water.

Chu Qingqiu was supposed to be on the mountain - how could she encounter Chu Qingqiu on the Marriage Bridge?

Jiuying had said she had indeed seen the Marriage God and the Marriage Brush he held, so perhaps the legend about this bridge was actually true.

Ning Fuyi unconsciously clenched her palms, her heart beating faster than the flickering lights.

Chu Qingqiu clearly hadn't expected to encounter Ning Fuyi either. She instinctively looked at the bells hanging on both sides of the bridge, only to discover that the wind that had been present earlier had suddenly stopped, and the bells fell instantly silent.

Her red lips pressed together, her eyes trembling slightly.

"If the wind chimes don't ring, then it's an ill-fated relationship." The man's earlier words echoed in her heart. Ning Fuyi also frowned, staring at those bells, unable to express the frustration in her heart.

"Does the Divine Venerable believe this legend?" Ning Fuyi suddenly spoke, her palm suddenly turning as air currents spread from her palm, making the motionless bells sway left and right.

Thus the ding-a-ling sound of wind chimes rang out again, spreading across the entire Marriage Bridge.

Footnotes:

¹ Bright Sun Grass (艳阳草) - A fictional herb that grows in bright sunlight, used for alchemy

² Qixi Festival (七夕) - Chinese Valentine's Day, celebrating the legend of the weaver girl and cowherd